Chapter 6 · Story

Two invitations. Different reasons to care.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The invitation · c06s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

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What would you do?

A potential volunteer worries about the time commitment. What information would help most?

A A second celebrity endorsement.

B Shift length, support, and an optional trial.

C A stronger claim that this is unmissable.

Suggested answer: B. Shift length, support, and an optional trial give the volunteer relevant information about the commitment.

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An evaluation is not a sign-up.

- **Attitude**: an evaluation of something.
- A resident may see volunteering as worthwhile.
- Time, transport, support, and choice also affect action.
- Decide which outcome the invitation should support.

An attitude is an evaluation

Possible evaluation



“Volunteering is worthwhile.” Reasons and values shape the judgment.

A different question



Will I sign up? Time, transport, support, and choice also affect action.

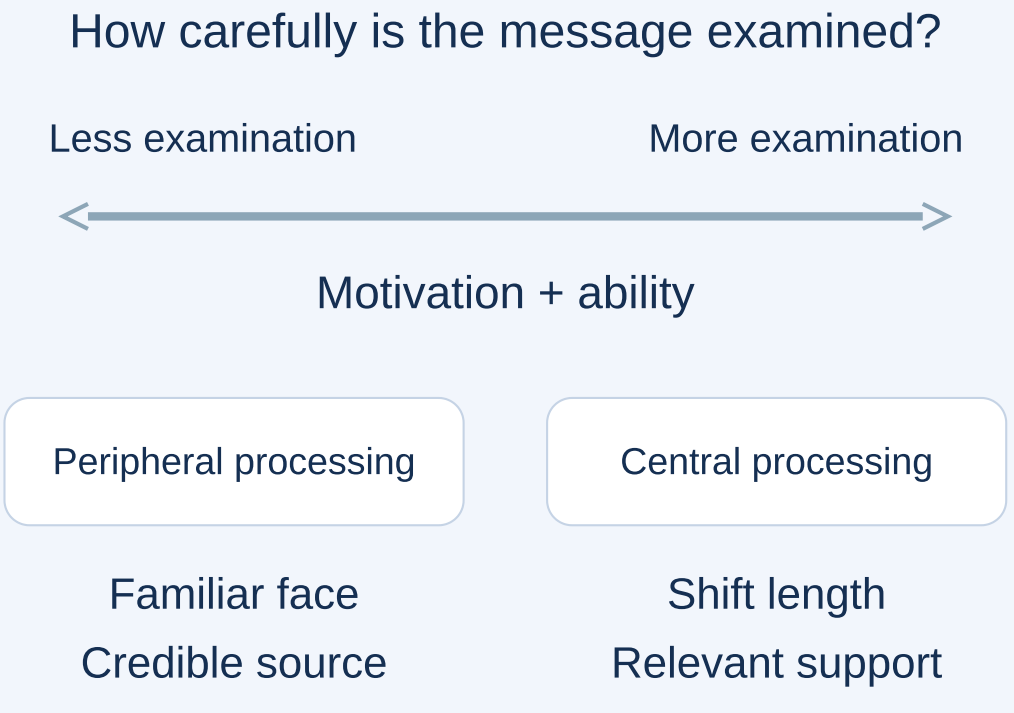
A positive attitude does not guarantee action.
Ask what outcome the message needs to support.

An evaluation and an action are related but distinct.

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How carefully is the message examined?

- **Elaboration likelihood model**: motivation and ability shape examination.
- **Central processing**: examine relevant arguments.
- **Peripheral processing**: give more weight to cues such as familiarity.
- These are processing differences, not fixed kinds of person.



The elaboration likelihood model describes processing, not fixed types of person.

The same person can process different messages more or less carefully.

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Check the truth of a norm claim.

- **Descriptive norm**: what people do.
- **Injunctive norm**: what people approve.
- Both example claims need evidence.
- Highlighting common nonparticipation can normalize it.

What happens and what is approved

Descriptive norm



“Many residents volunteer.”
A claim about what people do.

Injunctive norm



“Our community values volunteering.”
A claim about what people approve.

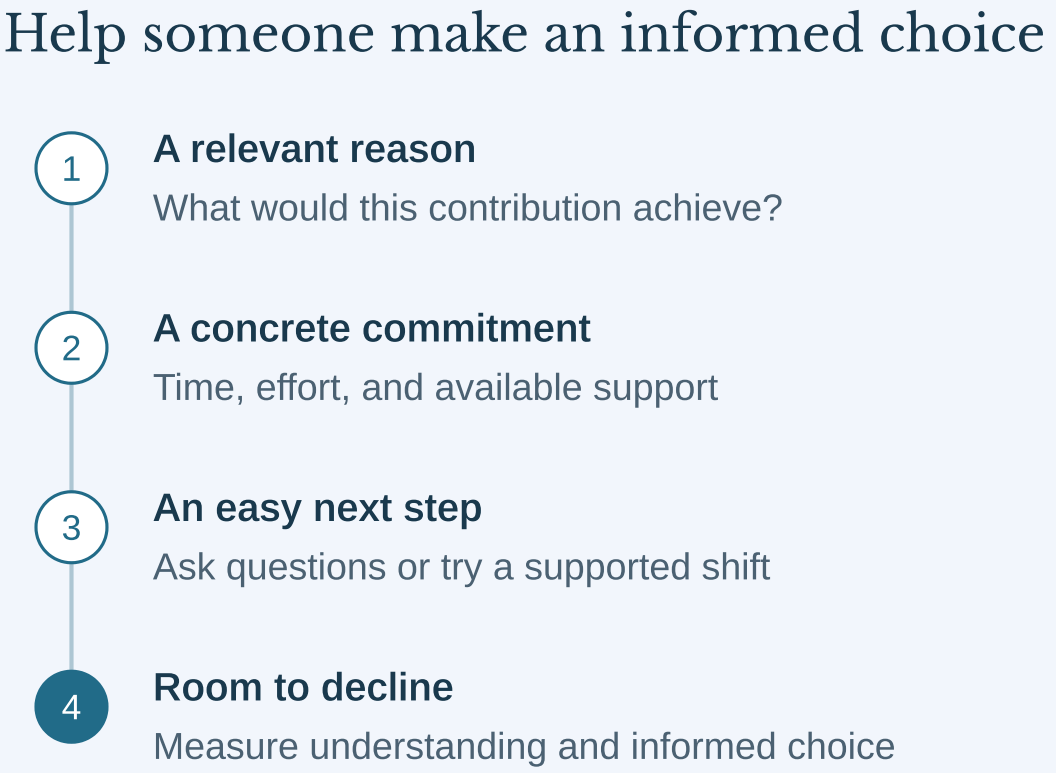
These are example claims; check their truth.
Highlighting low participation can normalize it.

Behavior and approval are different claims; both need evidence.

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Help someone make an informed choice.

- **Reason**: what would this contribution achieve?
- **Commitment**: state time, effort, and support.
- **Next step**: make questions or a supported trial possible.
- **Choice**: leave room to decline.



Remove unsupported claims about what others do.

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What can we really conclude?

Persuasion depends on the audience, topic, source, and outcome being measured. A changed survey answer is not the same outcome as sustained behavior change. For the café team, the next task is to evaluate its revised invitation. More clicks show increased attention; they do not establish that potential volunteers understood the commitment or will keep volunteering. The team can track comprehension, informed sign-ups, and continued participation. To learn about the volunteers' experience, ask them whether they understood the effort involved and felt able to decline. Their answers provide information that the organizers' impressions alone cannot supply.

Measure the outcome that matters

1. **Attention**
   An invitation gets a click
2. **Understanding**
   The person knows the commitment
3. **Informed sign-up**
   Participation is freely chosen
4. **Continued participation**
   Check experience and retention

A click alone does not establish these later outcomes.

Measure later outcomes rather than assuming them from clicks.

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Try the idea somewhere new.

Few residents currently volunteer. Which invitation is defensible?

A “Everyone here already volunteers.”

B “Hardly anyone helps—don’t be like them.”

C “Try a supported two-hour shift; here is what it involves.”

Suggested answer: C. A supported two-hour trial is a concrete, checkable request. Its effect on informed participation still needs evaluation.

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Close your notes. Explain it.

> What makes central processing more likely?

> Distinguish descriptive and injunctive norms.

1. Central processing is more likely when someone is motivated and has the ability, attention, and information to examine the arguments.

2. Descriptive norms concern what people do. Injunctive norms concern approval.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

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Carry one idea into your week.

Rewrite a low-stakes invitation. State the decision, relevant reason, effort required, and next step. Remove social-proof claims you cannot substantiate.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

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